Secular Order of Discalced Carmelites

Formation II
Year B

The Interior Castle

(The Seven Dwelling Places)

"Let us desire and be occupied in prayer
not for the sake of our enjoyment,
but so as to have this strength to serve.
Martha and Mary must join together
in order to show hospitality to the Lord…"

Interior Castle, VII, 4:12

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Introduction to Formation II

(Members who have made the First Promise)

Formation II is in preparation for the Definitive Promise and takes a minimum of three years, and in some instances, due to discernment by the candidate and the community's Council, may take longer. The purpose of this period of formation is to prepare the candidate to maturely make a lifetime commitment to living the Discalced Carmelite charism as expressed in the OCDS Constitutions. Deepening union with God in interior prayer should lead the candidate to grow in virtue, in the desire to serve others, and in faithfulness to the Evangelical Counsels and Beatitudes. Growth in community life continues to be an important aspect of formation. Because this period leads to the Definitive Promise, serious ongoing discernment of the vocation by the Council and the candidate is crucial during this time.

Candidate responsibilities:

- The candidate will strive to be consistent in the practices begun in earlier stages of formation and be faithful to the Promise made at the end of Formation I. (The noted references are not exhaustive; there are many others throughout the Constitutions, Provincial Statutes, and Ratio.)
- Attend and participate in monthly community meetings and formation sessions. (see Const. 24.b,c)
- Be conscientious in the study and internalization of assigned material and topics. (see Const. 24.d and 32-34)
- Continue to study and strive to live the OCDS Constitutions and Statutes. (see Const. Preface)
- Develop the habit of reading Church documents, especially those addressed to the laity. (see Const. 19 and Ratio 80)
- Read and reflect on Sacred Scripture regularly. (see Const. 19 and Ratio 15)
- Practice silent prayer (remain in God's presence with loving attention) daily for at least half an hour. (see Ratio 20-21, 90)
- Pray Morning Prayer and Evening Prayer of the Liturgy of the Hours. Pray Night Prayer if possible. (see Const. 6.d and 23-24)
- Participate in daily Mass as far as possible. (see Const. 6.d and 23-24)
- Continue the habit of daily examination of conscience (commonly included as part of Night Prayer).
- Fast on the vigils of the Carmelite feasts listed in the Provincial Statutes.
- Participate in the community apostolate. (see Const. 26)
- Share in the duties and responsibilities of the community as assigned by the local Council. (see Const. 15)
- Participate in community retreats and days of recollection. (see Const. 24.d)
- Most importantly, continue to strive for Christ-like charity toward all in the community, in the family, and in daily life. (1 Cor. 13)

The Specific Guidelines for Formation

It is important to keep clearly in mind the purpose of formation in Carmel and to strike a balance between "head" and "heart."

- "Number 32 of the Constitutions states that the purpose of formation is 'to prepare the person to live the [charism and] spirituality of Carmel.' This sentence of the Constitutions gives a very important emphasis to the purpose of formation, indicating those elements that are not the priorities in the progress of Carmel of formation. The purpose of the formation program is not to produce experts in Carmelite spirituality, nor to obtain a university degree in spirituality or spiritual theology" (Ratio Institutionis 4).
- "The purpose is to 'prepare the person.' The stress on the person who is to be prepared helps the formation community understand that the process must be directed to the individual in a concrete way. The people who come to the Secular Order of Carmel are, with few exceptions, people who have many commitments, especially with families and with work. The program of formation must be flexible enough to adapt to the circumstances of each person who is to become a member" (Ratio 5).
- "…The primary role of the person responsible for formation … is to **accompany** those in formation, to help them put into practice what they learn through the process of formation. The information they are given through reading and classes is meant to be a help to the person's spiritual growth" (Ratio 7). [emphasis added]
- "…With a progression suitable to the various stages, the candidate should get a clearer idea of how important, indeed necessary, our charism is for [one's] personal life…" (Ratio 23).
- "The spirituality of the Discalced Carmelites has a very sound intellectual foundation. There is a doctrine involved here. Any person who wants to be a Discalced Carmelite must be a person with interest in learning from the teachers of Carmel. There are three Doctors of the universal Church, Teresa, John of the Cross, and Therese" (Ratio 78).
- "There is an intellectual aspect to the formation of a Discalced Carmelite. There is a doctrinal basis to the spirituality and identity of one who is called to the Order. As the friars and nuns, the seculars too ought to have a good intellectual and doctrinal formation since as members of the Order they represent and witness to a mature and profound spirituality" (Ratio 79).

"These directors [formators] should reflect that they themselves are not the chief agent, guide, and mover of souls in this matter, but the principal guide is the Holy Spirit, who is never neglectful of souls, and they themselves are instruments for directing these souls to perfection through faith and the law of God, according to the spirit given by God to each one. Thus, the whole concern of the directors [formators] should not be to accommodate souls to their own method and condition, but they should observe the road along which God is leading one…"
(The Living Flame of Love, Stanza 3:46)

About the Syllabus

Required Reading: St. Teresa of Avila, The Interior Castle Study Edition, ICS Publications, 2010; or second edition, 2020 (page numbers differ)

Additional Reading:

Ahlgren, Gillian T.W., Entering Teresa of Avila's Interior Castle. A Reader's Companion, Paulist Press, 2005.

Alvarez, Thomas, OCD, St. Teresa of Avila, 100 Themes on Her Life and Work, ICS Publications, 2011, pages 337-358 on the Interior Castle.

Glossary pages 456-465 (second edition, pgs. 427-437).

Note: "Additional reading" is intended for personal enrichment and is not required.

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Explanatory note regarding "Essential points to discuss": The candidates and formator are expected to read and reflect on the materials and ponder the essential points prior to the monthly formation sessions. However, it would not be practical to try to discuss every point during the session. It is preferable to choose several points for in-depth discussion. It is good practice to discuss those points which make a personal impression on the participants.

Because formator participation is crucial to the candidates' formation, good preparation is indispensable. After the opening prayer and the discussion of the legislations, formators are encouraged to take about 10-15 minutes at the beginning of the session to talk about the session theme, the assigned reading, and a brief review of the points to be discussed before moving on to the discussion itself.

Studying the OCDS Legislations: Unless the community is studying these materials together, it is appropriate for each session to begin with ten minutes of discussion on some selection of the OCDS legislations or documents of the Order, as determined by the local Council.